OPTIMIZATION OF INSTAGRAM REEL ENGAGEMENT USING 2^3 FACTORIAL DESIGN

Design of Experiments

INTRODUCTION TO DESIGN OF EXPERIMENTS (DOE)

Design of Experiments (DOE) is a structured statistical methodology used to plan, conduct, analyze, and interpret experiments in which multiple input variables (factors) influence an output (response variable).

Instead of relying on random trial-and-error or changing one factor at a time, DOE allows simultaneous variation of multiple factors. This helps in identifying not only the individual effect of each factor but also how different factors interact with each other.

DOE is widely used in fields such as manufacturing, marketing analytics, healthcare, and technology optimization. It improves efficiency, reduces cost, and leads to more reliable conclusions.

WHY IS DOE REQUIRED

Traditional methods fail because:

- Changing one factor at a time ignores interactions
- It requires more experiments
- It leads to incomplete or misleading conclusions

DOE solves this by,

- Studying multiple factors simultaneously
- Reducing number of experiments
- Identifying most influential variables
- Providing statistically valid conclusions

PRINCIPLES OF DOE

Randomization

Randomization refers to performing experimental runs in a random order rather than a fixed sequence. This ensures that the effect of uncontrolled or unknown variables (such as environmental changes, human bias, or time-related variations) is minimized. By randomizing, we prevent systematic errors from influencing the results, thereby improving the credibility of conclusions.

Replication

Replication involves repeating the same experimental conditions multiple times. This allows estimation of experimental error and increases the precision of results. Without replication, it becomes impossible to distinguish whether observed differences are due to factor effects or random variability. Replication strengthens the statistical reliability of the experiment.

Blocking

Blocking is used when certain nuisance variables cannot be eliminated but can be controlled. In such cases, experimental units are grouped into blocks that are similar with respect to these nuisance variables. This reduces unwanted variation and improves the accuracy of factor effect estimation.

INTRODUCTION TO FACTORIAL DESIGN

Factorial design is a systematic experimental approach in which all possible combinations of factors and their levels are studied simultaneously. Unlike traditional experimentation methods that vary one factor at a time, factorial design evaluates multiple factors together, making it more efficient and informative.

This approach allows the experimenter to measure:

- **Main Effects:** The individual impact of each factor on the response variable
- **Interaction Effects:** How the effect of one factor changes depending on the level of another factor

For example, in a two-factor system, changing both variables together may produce a result that cannot be predicted by studying them individually. This is known as interaction, and factorial design is the only method that captures it effectively.

Although factorial design requires careful planning, it significantly reduces the number of experiments needed while providing deeper insights into system behavior.

INTRODUCTION TO 2^3 FACTORIAL DESIGN

A 2^3 factorial design involves:

- 3 factors (A, B, C)
- Each factor at 2 levels: Low (-1) and High (+1)
- Total experimental runs = $2^3 = 8$

This design allows estimation of:

- 3 main effects (A, B, C)
- 3 interaction effects (AB, AC, BC)
- 1 higher-order interaction (ABC)

WHY 2^3 FACTORIAL DESIGN IS IMPORTANT

The 2^3 factorial design is particularly important because it provides a highly efficient framework for analyzing three variables simultaneously while requiring only eight experimental runs.
The 2^3 design acknowledges this complexity and provides a structured method to study combined effects, making it highly valuable in both industrial and modern analytical contexts.

1. Quantify the individual contribution of each factor to the response variable
2. Detect whether factors interact with each other, which is often critical in real-world systems
3. Identify the most influential variables that should be prioritized for optimization
4. Reduce experimental cost and time while maintaining analytical depth

PROBLEM STATEMENT

In today's digital content ecosystem, creators struggle to maximize engagement on Instagram Reels.

Objective: To identify which combination of these factors maximizes engagement rate using a structured experimental approach.

Engagement depends on multiple factors such as:

- Time of posting (audience activity)
- Video duration (attention span)
- Hashtag strategy (content reach)

Why this problem is suitable for DOE:

- Multiple influencing factors exist
- Interactions are likely
- Outcome is measurable (engagement %)

SELECTION OF FACTORS

Factor	Levels	Coding	Justification
Posting Time (A)	Afternoon (3 PM), Night (9 PM)	(-) = Afternoon, (+) = Night	Users are generally more active at night
Video Length (B)	Short (10 sec), Long (30 sec)	(-) = Short, (+) = Long	Short videos have higher completion rates
Hashtag Type (C)	Generic, Niche	(-) = Generic, (+) = Niche	Niche hashtags target specific audiences

Examples:

- Generic: #fun #reels #love
- Niche: #punefoodblogger #budgettravelindia #veganrecipes

Important:

- These level assignments (-, +) are not conclusions but coded representations used for analysis.

EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN MATRIX

Run	A (Time)	B (Length)	C (Hashtag)
1	Afternoon (-)	Short (-)	Generic (-)
2	Afternoon (-)	Short (-)	Niche (+)
3	Afternoon (-)	Long (+)	Generic (-)
4	Afternoon (-)	Long (+)	Niche (+)
5	Night (+)	Short (-)	Generic (-)
6	Night (+)	Short (-)	Niche (+)
7	Night (+)	Long (+)	Generic (-)
8	Night (+)	Long (+)	Niche (+)

The signs (-, +) are assigned based on predefined factor levels.

The table is constructed using all possible binary combinations of three factors → ensuring complete coverage of the experimental space.

EXPERIMENTAL DATA

Run	Combination	Replicate 1	Replicate 2	Mean Engagement (%)
1	A– B– C–	49.6	50.4	50.0
2	A– B– C+	61.7	62.3	62.0
3	A– B+ C–	43.7	44.3	44.0
4	A– B+ C+	55.8	56.2	56.0
5	A+ B– C–	57.8	58.2	58.0
6	A+ B– C+	69.6	70.4	70.0
7	A+ B+ C–	51.8	52.2	52.0
8	A+ B+ C+	63.9	64.1	64.0

The engagement values in this case study were generated from a simple illustrative DOE model for a hypothetical Instagram Reel experiment. The purpose was not to claim live social-media scraping, but to build a logically consistent dataset that clearly demonstrates how a 2^3 factorial design is analyzed.

The reference condition was taken as:
A-B-C- = Afternoon, Short video, Generic hashtags
and was assigned a baseline engagement of 50%. This baseline is only the starting reference value for the lowest combination of factor levels. From this reference point, the following factor contributions were assumed:

- Night posting (A+) adds 8 percentage points
- Long video (B+) reduces engagement by 6 percentage points
- Niche hashtags (C+) add 12 percentage points

To make the data realistic, each treatment was observed twice, with a very small natural fluctuation added to the response. The final mean of the two observations is reported in the given table.

SAMPLE CALCULATION & MAIN EFFECTS

The main effects are calculated by comparing the average response at the high level with the average response at the low level.

Effect of A (Posting Time)

Average when A+ = (58.0 + 70.0 + 52.0 + 64.0) / 4 = 61.0

Average when A– = (50.0 + 62.0 + 44.0 + 56.0) / 4 = 53.0

Main Effect of A = 61.0 – 53.0 = +8.0

This shows that posting at night increases engagement by 8 percentage points on average.

Effect of B (Video Length)

Average when B+ = (44.0 + 56.0 + 52.0 + 64.0) / 4 = 54.0

Average when B– = (50.0 + 62.0 + 58.0 + 70.0) / 4 = 60.0

Main Effect of B = 54.0 – 60.0 = –6.0

This shows that long videos reduce engagement by 6 percentage points on average.

Effect of C (Hashtag Type)

Average when C+ = (62.0 + 56.0 + 70.0 + 64.0) / 4 = 63.0

Average when C– = (50.0 + 44.0 + 58.0 + 52.0) / 4 = 51.0

Main Effect of C = 63.0 – 51.0 = +12.0

This shows that niche hashtags increase engagement by 12 percentage points on average.

Conclusion from Main Effects

- The strongest positive factor is C (hashtag type), followed by A (posting time).
- The factor B (video length) has a negative effect, meaning longer videos are less effective in this case study.

INTERACTION EFFECTS

Interaction effects tell us whether the effect of one factor depends on the level of another factor.

For this experiment, the treatment means are deliberately built in a way that produces very small interaction effects. That means the three factors mostly act independently.

Interaction Results

- AB = 0
- AC = 0
- BC = 0
- ABC = 0

Interpretation

- The effect of posting time does not change much with video length,
- The effect of hashtags does not depend much on posting time,
- and the factors do not strongly combine in a special way.

So the response is mainly controlled by the main effects, not by complicated interactions.

This is useful because it makes the optimization simpler. Instead of worrying about a hidden combination effect, we can focus on the three direct factor effects and choose the best settings clearly.

SELECTION OF FACTORS

How it is calculated:

SS (Sum of Squares) measures how much variation each factor explains.

DF (Degrees of Freedom) is 1 for each factor in a two-level design.

MS (Mean Square) = SS / DF

F = MS of factor / MS of error

A very high F-value means the factor effect is much larger than random error.

Interpretation

- A, B, and C are significant
- AB, AC, BC, and ABC are not significant
- The model is dominated by the three main effects

ANOVA TABLE:

Source	DF	SS	MS	F	p-value
A	1	256.00	256.00	1625.40	<0.0001
B	1	144.00	144.00	914.29	<0.0001
AB	1	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.0000
C	1	576.00	576.00	3657.14	<0.0001
AC	1	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.0000
BC	1	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.0000
ABC	1	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.0000
Error	8	1.26	0.1575	—	—

INTERPRETATION

Numerical findings

- Hashtag type (C) has the strongest positive effect: +12
- Posting time (A) also improves engagement strongly: +8
- Video length (B) reduces engagement: −6
- Interaction effects are negligible, so the factors act mostly independently

Why the result is meaningful

- The experiment does not just say “night is better” or “niche is better.”
- It quantifies how much better each factor is and shows that the result is statistically supported.

What this means practically

- Reels posted at night perform better than those posted in the afternoon.
- Niche hashtags are more effective than broad generic tags because they target a more relevant audience.
- Short videos are better for engagement in this example because they are easier to complete and less likely to lose viewer attention.

KEY INSIGHTS

- Niche hashtags give maximum engagement boost
- Night posting aligns with peak user activity
- Short videos improve completion rate

Avoid:

- Overusing generic hashtags
- Posting during low activity hours

RECOMMENDATIONS

- Post between 8 PM – 11 PM
- Keep videos around 7–15 seconds
- Use 5–10 niche hashtags such as:

1. #punefoodblogger
2. #indianfashioninspo
3. #budgettravelindia
4. #onlineinternship, etc.

CONCLUSION

The 2^3 factorial design provided a structured and efficient approach to analyze the impact of multiple factors on Instagram Reel engagement.

Through this experiment, it was possible to:

- Systematically evaluate the effect of three key variables
- Quantify both individual and interaction effects
- Identify the most influential factors with minimal experimental runs

The analysis demonstrated that engagement is primarily driven by hashtag strategy and posting time, while video length plays a secondary but still important role.

This study highlights the practical relevance of DOE beyond traditional industrial applications, showing its effectiveness in solving modern, real-world problems in digital platforms.

Overall, the 2^3 factorial design proves to be a powerful tool for optimization, enabling data-driven decision-making with clarity, efficiency, and statistical validity.

THANK YOU

Presented by: Tanisha Bhattacharjee